Enterprise Reporting & Automation Strategy

Problem Analysis:

RetailHub is a growing retail and e-commerce company managing 50 physical stores alongside an online marketplace. Despite handling large volumes of data daily, the company still relies heavily on manual, spreadsheet-driven processes. This gap between the data they collect and how they use it is causing real operational pain. Below are the core problems identified:

1. Key Challenges

- **Manual reporting:** Sales and finance reports are created manually
- **No real-time visibility:** Inventory managers can't track live stock
- **Data scattered:** Multiple systems (sales, inventory, finance)
- **Customer support overload:** Repetitive queries about order status process
- **No dashboards:** Management lacks real-time insights for decision-making

2. Why Spreadsheets Are Not Suitable

- **Not scalable:** Cannot handle large enterprise data efficiently
- **Error-prone:** Manual entry leads to mistakes
- **No real-time updates:** Data becomes outdated quickly
- **Poor collaboration:** Multiple versions create confusion
- **No automation:** Repetitive tasks done manually
- **Weak security:** Limited control over data access

3. Operational Inefficiencies Due to Manual Processes

- **Time-consuming reporting:** Manual creation of sales and finance reports delays decisions
- **Higher error rates:** Manual data entry increases chances of mistakes
- **Delayed insights:** No real-time data leads to slow response to issues
- **Inefficient inventory management:** Leads to stock-outs or overstocking
- **Repetitive work:** Same tasks (reports, updates) done again and again
- **Increased workload on staff:** Employees spend time on routine tasks instead of strategic work

Power Platform Solution Design

Business Problem	Power Platform Tool	Proposed Solution
Lack of business insights	Power BI	Create interactive dashboards for sales, inventory, and regional performance
Manual reporting (sales & finance)	Power Automate	Automate report generation and sharing on daily/monthly basis
No real-time inventory tracking	Power BI	Real-time inventory dashboards with alerts for low stock
Inefficient internal processes	Power Apps	Build apps for order management and inventory updates
Repetitive approval processes	Power Automate	Automate approval workflows for orders and payments
Customer support overload	Power Virtual Agents	Chatbot for order status, delivery updates, and FAQs

SSRS Reporting Strategy

1. Reports Best Suited for SSRS

- Pixel-perfect, formatted reports
- Printable reports (PDF/Excel)
- Scheduled and paginated reports
- Detailed transactional reports

2. Why SSRS is Ideal for Financial/Operational Reporting

- Provides accurate and structured reports
- Ensures consistent formatting (important for finance)
- Supports scheduled delivery (daily/monthly reports)
- Suitable for audit and compliance requirements

Examples of SSRS Reports

- **Invoice reports** – Generated for each customer purchase
- **Daily store sales reports** – Shows total sales per store each day
- **Financial statements** – Monthly profit, revenue, and expenses
- **Inventory summaries** – Stock levels and product availability

Tool Comparison

Criteria	SSRS	Power Bi
Reporting Type	Paginated (fixed format)	Interactive dashboards
Best Use Case	Operational Reports	Business analytics & insights
Visualization Capability	Basic	Advanced (charts, graphs, KPIs)
User Interaction	Low	High

Tool RetailHub Should Use

- **Use SSRS** for:
  - Financial reports (invoices, statements)
  - Daily operational reports
  - Printable and scheduled reports
- **Use Power BI** for:
  - Sales and performance dashboards
  - Real-time inventory monitoring
  - Regional and trend analysis

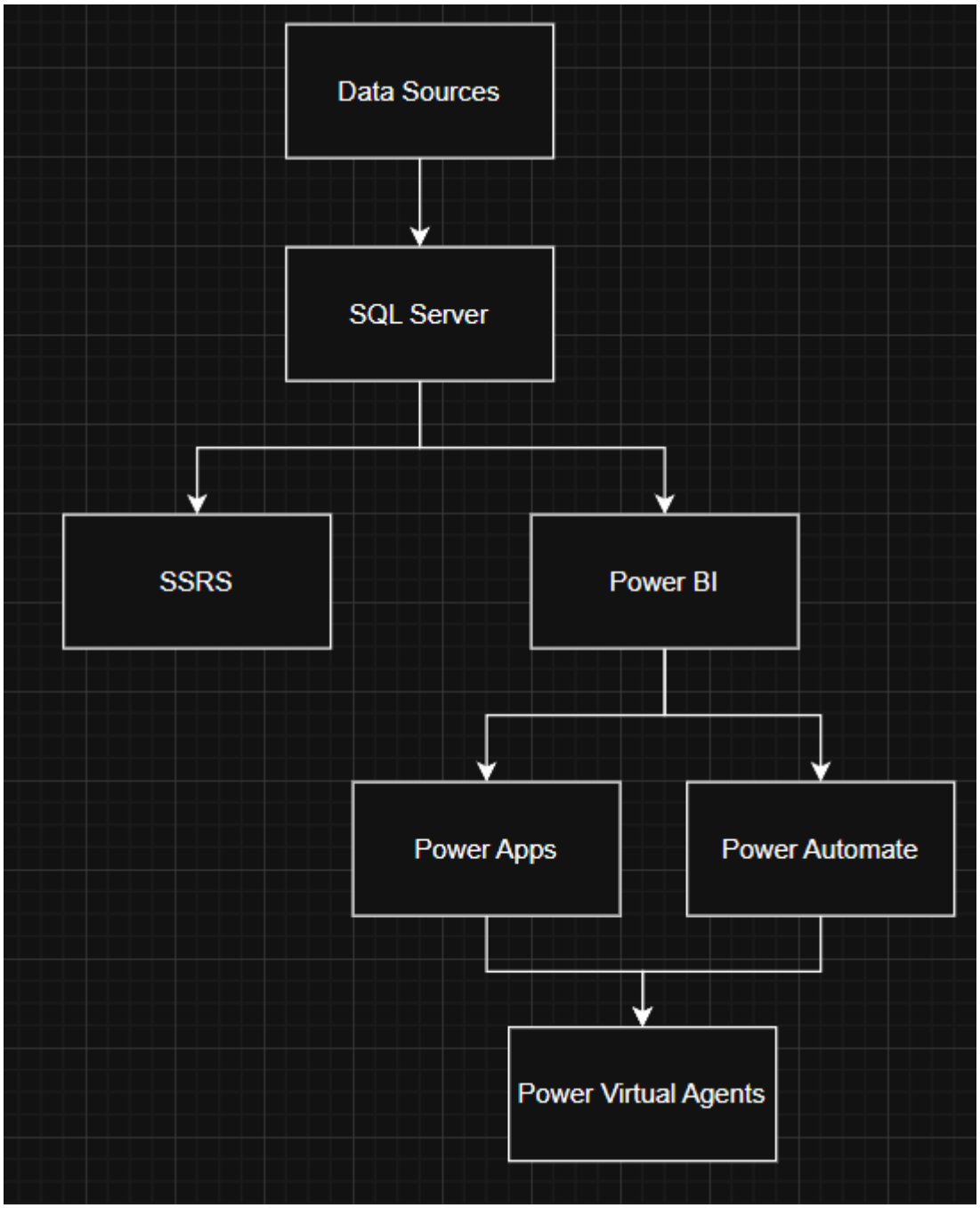
Proposed Solution Architecture

Step-by-Step Architecture Explanation

1. **Data Sources**
   Sales system, inventory system, customer orders, supplier database, and finance system generate data.
2. **Central Database**
   All business data is stored and managed in SQL Server.
3. **SSRS Reports**
   SQL Server data is used by SSRS to generate fixed, detailed, and printable operational reports such as invoices, daily sales reports, and financial statements.
4. **Power BI Dashboards**
   The same data is used in Power BI to create interactive dashboards for management analysis, KPIs, trends, and regional performance.
5. **Power Apps**
   Internal users can use Power Apps for processes like order updates, stock entry, and approvals.

6. **Power Automate**
   Power Automate handles workflows such as report sharing, alerts, and approval notifications.

7. **Power Virtual Agents**
   Customers can use chatbots to check order status, delivery updates, and common queries.



Final Reflection

A combined approach using Power Platform and SSRS is beneficial because it covers both operational reporting and modern business analytics. SSRS is useful for structured, detailed,

and printable reports such as invoices, financial statements, and daily operational reports. Power BI helps management with interactive dashboards, real-time insights, and performance analysis. At the same time, Power Apps improves internal business processes, Power Automate reduces manual work through automation, and Power Virtual Agents enhances customer support with chatbots. Together, these tools create an integrated solution that improves reporting accuracy, saves time, increases efficiency, and supports faster decision-making. This combined strategy helps enterprises modernize their operations while meeting both daily reporting needs and long-term business goals.